

Questions to ask at the dealer — 12 Sep 2026

Rules before you start

1. **Negotiate the out-the-door total. Never the monthly payment.** A monthly figure hides the term, the rate, and the add-ons.
2. **Do not let anyone run your credit** unless you are actually buying today. Refusing costs you nothing.
3. **Get every number by email.** A number you cannot forward is not a quote.
4. **Do not sign anything today.**
5. **Get a bank or credit-union pre-approval first.** That rate is your only leverage. Let the dealer try to beat it.

Ask at every dealer

Price

1. What is the **out-the-door price** on this exact car? Email it to me itemised.
2. What is your **doc fee**? (*Washington caps it at \$200, and RCW 46.70.180 makes it negotiable. Push for zero.*)
3. Is there any **market adjustment** or additional dealer markup?
4. List **every dealer-installed accessory** on this car with its price. Which can come off?
5. Is there a **manufacturer rebate or customer cash** right now? Does it stack with the low APR, or is it either/or?
6. What **APR** can I get, and at what credit tier? Is there a manufacturer subsidised rate?

The specific car

7. What is the **VIN**? Email it.
8. Is this car **on this lot right now**, or in transit? If in transit, what date does it land?
9. What is the **odometer reading**?
10. Has it been a **demo, test-drive unit, or service loaner**? Has it ever been registered? (*Ask for this in writing.*)

Ownership cost

11. What does **scheduled maintenance cost for the first five years**?
12. What is the **warranty** — basic, powertrain, and hybrid battery — in years and miles?
13. Is any **free maintenance** included, and for how long?

Getting the car you actually want

14. Can you **locate this spec via an inter-dealer trade**? Which colours and which trims, and how long? (*Ask for a locate, not a factory order. A trade is days to weeks. An order is months.*)

Toyota — the RAV4

The car on the sticker is a **2026 RAV4 XLE Premium, FWD, conventional hybrid**, VIN

2T36DRBV5TW026590, total MSRP **\$38,834**, out-the-door about **\$43,913**.

1. **Is VIN 2T36DRBV5TW026590 physically on your lot today?** Send me a timestamped photo of the window sticker on the glass.
2. **Which trims can have a moonroof?** The XLE Premium on the lot has none. What does the cheapest moonroof-capable trim cost against this car's \$36,100 base?
3. Which **colours** are available on that trim? Does any carry a paint charge?
4. Confirm **ToyotaCare is 2 years / 25,000 miles** on this 2026 car. *(It drops to 1 year / 10,000 miles on the 2027, so this matters.)*
5. Can you **absorb the \$425 rear cargo lamps?** *(A genuine Toyota port option, so they probably will not remove it — use it as a discount lever instead.)*
6. What **APR** is available on a 2026 RAV4 Hybrid?
7. What is the **FWD versus AWD** price and fuel-economy difference? *(You do not need AWD. Do not let them upsell it.)*
8. **Is the 2026 RAV4 the first year of a new generation?** *(Car and Driver says Toyota gave it a "tip-to-tail re-do" for 2026. Their answer tells you how straight they are being.)*

Mazda — the CX-50 Hybrid

1. **Does the 0% for 36 months apply to the CX-50 Hybrid specifically?** *(It does. Mazda's own fine print names "CX-50 Hybrid". Their answer tests whether they know their own offer.)*
2. Is there **customer cash** on the CX-50 Hybrid, and does it **stack** with the 0%? *(The \$1,000 appears on the CX-5, not the Hybrid.)*
3. **What is the dealer contribution on this car?** *(Mazda's terms say "dealer contribution may vary and could affect purchase price." This is where a subsidised rate quietly eats your discount.)*
4. Give me the **out-the-door price with the 0%, and again without it**. Compare the totals, not the rates.
5. What are the **exact trim prices for the CX-50 Hybrid?** *(Only "from \$34,750 excluding destination" is confirmed. Destination is \$1,530.)*
6. Can you **deliver before 30 September**, which is when the 0% expires?
7. Mazda includes **no free maintenance**. Confirm that, and price the plan.
8. **Have any 2026 CX-5 customers come back with infotainment problems?** *(Watch the reaction as much as the answer. Car and Driver's long-term CX-5 still bricks its screen at 10,000 miles, and a dealer software update did not fix it.)*

Honda — the CR-V Hybrid

1. What are the **trim prices**, and what do you have in stock? *(Range is \$37,080 to \$44,000 including destination.)*

2. Confirm **Honda Service Pass** — is it 1 year / 12,000 miles, and what does it cover? (*Sources disagree, so confirm for this specific car.*)
3. What **APR** is available?
4. Is a **moonroof** standard or optional, and on which trims?

Refuse these at the finance desk

The sticker is clean now. This is where things get added.

- Paint protection, fabric protection, ceramic coating
- Nitrogen-filled tyres
- VIN etching
- Pinstriping, door edge guards, wheel locks
- Extended warranty (*you can buy this later, cheaper, elsewhere*)
- GAP insurance (*your own insurer sells it cheaper*)
- Any "protection package"

Say once, plainly: **"No additional products. Just the car."**

Write these down for every car

Do it in the car park, before you drive off. Memory fails fast across several cars.

Field	Value
Model year and trim	
Powertrain: full hybrid or plug-in	
FWD or AWD	
VIN	
Colour, and options fitted	
Total MSRP	
Out-the-door quoted	
Odometer	
Moonroof?	
Rear seat measurement — driver's seatback to rear cushion, with the seat where you actually drive	
Car seat fitted comfortably?	
Would I keep this eight years?	

Before you commit, later

1. **Insurance quotes by VIN** for each car. You have no US insurance history, so expect a surcharge. Shop 6–10 carriers including **PEMCO**, and enrol in telematics from day one.
2. **Out-the-door quotes in writing** from every dealer, then compare.
3. **Your own financing pre-approval**, before you take any dealer rate.